



fields, where access is often restricted by tight professional circles. A mentor's introduction can open doors, but sustaining these connections requires trust and strong work ethics.

### The flip side

Now that we have seen the positives, let's consider the negatives.

Internships can be valuable, but they also come with drawbacks. Here are some common challenges:

**Low or no pay:** Many internships are unpaid or offer very little compensation, which can be frustrating if you're putting in significant effort (even if mutually agreed on a pro bono basis).

**Limited learning opportunities:** Many internships involve repetitive tasks, admin work, or simple data entry, offering minimal career growth or experience.

**High competition:** Securing a good internship can be tough due to high demand, making it stressful to land a meaningful position.

**Unclear job role:** In India, interns often face vague responsibilities or a

lack of guidance, leading to an unproductive experience.

**Time commitment:** Internships can be demanding, making it difficult to balance with studies, personal life, or part-time jobs.

**No full-time job guarantee:** Even with excellent performance, there's no certainty of a full-time job offer at the end of an internship.

**Potential exploitation:** Some companies use interns as cheap labour without offering proper training or growth opportunities, which can demotivate aspiring professionals.

**Relocation costs:** Internships in other cities or countries may require significant personal investment in travel, accommodation, and daily expenses, often without financial support.

**Paying for internships:** Recently, there has been increasing exploitation of interns, with mentors charging large sums under the pretext of providing knowledge and experience, which needs to be seriously scrutinised by interns and organisations.

**The perfect guide:** Toni, Rafael Nadal's uncle and coach, instilled in the champion a strong work ethic and discipline from childhood. GETTY IMAGES

**Mentor creating a false aura about themselves:** In the current scenario, some interns are misled by mentors who create a false narrative about their expertise or rarity in the field of sports science. This makes interns feel obliged or overly grateful to be interning under these misleading professionals.

**Identifying the right one:** Choosing your mentor or the company is the most critical part. Wrong choice of mentor can be counterproductive to your professional growth.

### It's time to get started soon

A good mentor can be a source of support, a trusted advisor, and potentially a lifelong friend. The impact of a great mentor can be one of the most powerful and transformative influences in your career — so seek one out!